

fourth, altering the tenacious story in one brutal stroke.

Final reckoning

Few expected a three-way battle this year, not even the latest entrant himself. With only two races remaining, momentum sat with Verstappen, who had won the first of the concluding triple-header and was now just 24 points shy of Norris.

At the penultimate Qatar race, a catastrophic strategy call hit both McLarens hard. Piastri fell from a near-certain victory to second, Norris dropped from second to fourth, and winner Verstappen vaulted to second in the standings, turning the chase into a knife-edge clash.

The finale arrived with permutations and echoes of past contests looming large. The leader held a 12-point advantage, while just four points separated second and third, with 25 still on offer. All eyes were on the hunters and the hunted.

Qualifying was intense. Verstappen claimed pole, Norris second, Piastri third. But attitudes diverged: Verstappen seemed content with a shot, Piastri nearly resigned to falling short, and Norris reminded himself quietly that the pinnacle was within reach.

Norris knew better than to tussle with Verstappen, a man who had repeatedly edged him in wheel-to-wheel fights. On the first lap, the Briton took the safe route, but was overtaken by a determined Piastri. Third was still enough, but he had to defend it with everything he had.

With gutsy moves, he threaded past midfielders, even two in a single turn. Anticipating that Yuki Tsunoda would play the team game for his Red Bull senior, Norris pushed every limit to climb back. By the final laps, he knew he had done enough.

When the chequered flag fell, the release was instant. The tears, the weight, the years of effort converged at once. New fights will come and new mountains will rise, but for this moment, he stands exactly where he long dreamed of being.

MCLAREN'S PUSH TO KEEP BOTH DRIVERS ON EQUAL FOOTING BECAME A NEAR-CONSTANT TALKING POINT THROUGH THE 2025 SEASON

